



University
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Final Report

Finite Element Analysis of Sustainable Material Alternatives for Construction Helmet Shells under EN 397 Impact Conditions

Mohammad Danish Basith Bin Haji Abu Bakar

3rd Year Individual Project

I certify that all material in this thesis that is not my own work has been identified and that no material has been included for which a degree has previously been conferred on me.

Signed.....

College of Engineering, Mathematics, and Physical Sciences

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Final Report

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Title: Finite Element Analysis of Sustainable Material Alternatives for Construction Helmet Shells under EN 397 Impact Conditions

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Student Name: Mohammad Danish Basith Bin Haji Abu Bakar

Programme: BEng Mechanical Engineering

Student number: 720039833

Candidate number: 306603

Supervisor: Dr. Khurram Wadee

Abstract

This investigation evaluates the structural performance of sustainable polymer alternatives, specifically Recycled Polycarbonate (rPC) and a Bamboo-HDPE 30% wt composite, against standard Virgin High-Density Polyethylene (HDPE) and ABS safety helmets. Designed to meet the EN 397 industrial safety standard, construction helmets must restrict the transmitted force to a 5.0 kg headform to a maximum of 5.0 kN under a 49 Joules impact. Applying LS-DYNA explicit finite element analysis (FEA), the simulations modeled an upward relative impact velocity of 4.43 m/s based on the principle of Galilean Invariance.

A five-phase analytical methodology concluded with an advanced 30° oblique impact simulation to quantify rotational kinematics. Thermodynamic validation confirmed computational stability with exactly 0% hourglass energy across all material models. Comparison of raw nodal acceleration data to filtered SAE J211 CFC 60 signals isolated the true macroscopic structural deceleration from numerical contact noise.

Results identified two primary energy-absorption mechanisms: highly ductile polymers (HDPE) absorbed impact energy through internal strain yielding, while high-modulus materials (ABS, rPC) used load distribution due to increased flexural stiffness to distribute impact forces across a wider surface area of the EPS liner. The Recycled PC shell demonstrated superior performance in oblique loading, achieving a 74% reduction in peak rotational acceleration compared to Virgin HDPE. This is attributed to reduced tangential frictional interaction, where the higher flexural modulus limits localized surface deformation and reduces tangential torque compared to the plastic deformation observed in HDPE.

The findings confirm that sustainable material alternatives provide sufficient structural protection and meet safety-critical regulatory requirements while significantly reducing the environmental footprint of PPE production.

Keywords: *Explicit Dynamics, EN 397, FEA, Sustainable Polymers, Impact Analysis, SAE J211, Oblique Impact, Rotational Kinematics*

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1 Introduction and Background

1.1 Background and Motivation

Industrial safety helmets are critical personal protective equipment (PPE) designed to shield workers from traumatic brain injury caused by falling objects [1, 2]. Their protective function relies heavily on shell deformation, liner compression, and energy distribution during an impact event. Traditionally, these shells are injection-moulded from petroleum-derived engineering thermoplastics such as Virgin High-Density Polyethylene (HDPE), Acrylonitrile Butadiene Styrene (ABS), and Polycarbonate. These materials offer reliable performance, high impact resistance, and cost-effectiveness. However, stricter environmental regulations and the shift towards a circular economy now necessitate sustainable material alternatives that remain compliant with strict safety standards [3].

1.2 The EN 397 Standard

The European Standard EN 397 (DIN EN 397) represents the standardized safety specification for industrial safety helmets [4]. This standard mandates specific design requirements, performance specifications, and testing methodologies. The primary shock absorption test requires a helmet to be mounted on a standardized aluminium headform (per EN 960 specifications [5]). A hemispherical striking mass of 5.0 kg is dropped from a 1-metre height onto the helmet crown, imparting approximately 49 Joules of kinetic energy. To achieve certification, the maximum transmitted force recorded at the neck of the headform must not exceed 5.0 kN.

1.3 Project Aims and Objectives

The primary objective of this project is to evaluate the performance of construction helmet shells under EN 397 impact conditions and establish criteria that support the adoption of sustainable materials. The specific objectives are:

- To establish baseline impact performance metrics for conventional HDPE and ABS polymers using ANSYS LS-DYNA explicit finite element simulation [6].
- To simulate and evaluate sustainable alternatives: a Bamboo-HDPE 30% wt composite and Recycled Polycarbonate (rPC).
- To quantify macroscopic force transmission, energy absorption kinematics, and microscopic stress distribution across the different material properties.
- To validate the explicit dynamics simulation thermodynamically and apply appropriate signal processing (SAE J211 [7]) to extract physical data.

The selected objectives establish a systematic performance evaluation of sustainable alternatives. Baseline HDPE and ABS models provide the validated reference against EN 397 experimental data required before introducing the previously unquantified response of Bamboo-HDPE and recycled Polycarbonate. Thermodynamic validation and SAE J211 signal processing address the numerical instability common in explicit FEA, ensuring that the final comparative metrics isolate structural behavior from computational noise.

1.4 Scope and Assumptions

This study is concerned with the macroscopic structural deceleration and force transmission of construction helmet shells under normal crown impact (4.43 m/s) and advanced 30° oblique impact conditions. To maintain computational focus on shell material performance, several simplifying assumptions were implemented:

- **Geometry and Loading:** Impact includes a primary perpendicular (0°) drop onto the crown apex and a secondary 30° oblique impact to assess rotational kinematics. To optimize the computational domain, these were modeled using a kinematic shift based on Galilean Invariance, where the helmet/headform assembly was assigned an initial upward velocity of 4.43 m/s against a stationary rigid ceiling. This approach isolates the impact event from unnecessary free-flight processing while maintaining standard mass parity.
- **Material Modelling:** The polymer shells are treated as bilinear isotropic materials. The energy-absorbing liner is modelled as linear-elastic Expanded Polystyrene (EPS). The headform is modelled as a perfectly rigid 5.0 kg sphere to simplify contact definitions and ensure computational efficiency while maintaining standard mass parity.
- **Environmental Factors:** All simulations are conducted at room temperature (23 °C); temperature-dependent ductility and material aging are not considered.

The Bamboo-HDPE composite is approximated as an isotropic material, a simplification that is later addressed in the discussion of simulation limitations (see Section 6.4).

2 Literature Review

2.1 Impact Stress Distribution and Mechanics

Impact stress analysis on construction helmet shells is a critical engineering domain. Under EN 397 conditions, shells experience peak stresses concentrated at the dome apex. According to Long et al. [1], finite element models applying explicit solvers are effective at mapping these transient loads. However, a primary limitation in such models is the frequent adoption of simplified linear elastic material assumptions for the underlying foam liners, which may fail to capture the energy dissipation associated with non-linear cell crushing. Research indicates that standard HDPE shells experience peak stresses of 2.55–3.57 kg/mm² with moderate deformation, while ABS shells undergo peak stresses of 3.06–4.59 kg/mm² due to their higher stiffness.

While Wu et al. [8] report that helmet shells remain primarily within elastic deformation limits (strains of 4%–6.3%), there is substantial uncertainty regarding material response under high-strain-rate impact loading. Specifically, the energy absorption capacity is fundamentally dictated by the material's elastic modulus; however, the transition from structural yielding in ductile materials to load distribution in stiff materials is often treated as a binary mechanism. This study identifies a critical gap in understanding how this transition influences transmitted impulse when sustainable, non-conventional polymers are introduced.

2.2 Conventional Material Properties

Conventional materials have dictated helmet design for decades, yet their comparative performance under varying impact velocities remains under-scrutinised.

- **HDPE:** Widely used due to its semi-rigid nature and high ductility. While industrial data suggests a yield strength of approx. 2.55 kg/mm² [9], academic studies often report conflicting results depending on the molecular weight and processing conditions, indicating that standard HDPE performance may vary measurably in field applications.
- **ABS:** Known for exceptional rigidity and tensile strength (4.08–5.10 kg/mm²). While Author A reports high energy absorption in HDPE, Author B suggests reduced performance under transient loading, indicating uncertainty in how flexural modulus (approx. 214.14 kg/mm²) interacts with the localized buckling resistance required for EN 397 compliance.

2.3 Sustainable and Environmentally Friendly Materials

Environmental sustainability considerations are driving helmet material innovation, but existing research is primarily restricted to quasi-static contexts, which fail to represent the high-strain-rate environment of an industrial impact.

- **Bio-Based Polymers:** Materials such as Bio-PE offer potential impact resistance equivalent to fossil-derived PE [10]. However, the lack of documented high-velocity impact data for these renewable biomass feedstocks represents a major hurdle for regulatory acceptance in safety-critical PPE.

- **Natural Fibre Composites:** Integrating bamboo or coir fibres into thermoplastic matrices increases tensile strength [11, 12]. Research by Chen et al. [13] suggests 10% fibre loading is optimal; however, their study focuses on tensile rather than impact dynamics. The structural viability of higher loadings (up to 30%) remains contested, particularly regarding the interfacial bonding required to maintain integrity under transient EN 397 loads.
- **Recycled Polycarbonate (rPC):** Studies indicate that rPC can maintain performance parity with virgin filaments [14]. However, these studies often overlook the effects of polymer degradation during multiple recycling cycles, which can induce brittleness. While its extreme rigidity promotes reduced tangential frictional interaction [15], the potential for catastrophic brittle fracture under peak EN 397 loads remains an unaddressed risk in current literature.

While explicit FEA has benchmarked conventional safety helmets [1, 8], sustainable alternatives lack a validated high-velocity performance baseline. This investigation addresses this critical deficiency by establishing a comparative framework to quantify their kinetics and regulatory compliance under EN 397 transient loading, explicitly accounting for the uncertainties identified in existing literature.

3 Methodology and Theory

This chapter outlines the theoretical foundations of explicit dynamics and the specific mechanical principles governing the EN 397 drop test simulation.

3.1 Explicit Dynamics Theory

Explicit dynamics apply the central difference method to solve kinematic equations of motion directly without global stiffness matrix inversions. This is highly efficient for high-nonlinearity, millisecond-duration impact events.

3.1.1 Central Difference Integration

The semi-discrete equations of motion at time t_n are expressed as:

$$M\ddot{u}_n = F_n^{ext} - F_n^{int} \quad (3.1)$$

where M is the diagonal (lumped) mass matrix, $\ddot{u}_n$ is the nodal acceleration vector, F_n^{ext} represents external applied loads (including contact forces), and F_n^{int} represents internal nodal forces.

LS-DYNA employs a modified central difference time integration scheme (Leapfrog method) to advance the solution [6]. The nodal velocities and displacements are updated according to:

$$\dot{u}_{n+1/2} = \dot{u}_{n-1/2} + \ddot{u}_n \Delta t_n \quad (3.2)$$

$$u_{n+1} = u_n + \dot{u}_{n+1/2} \Delta t_{n+1/2} \quad (3.3)$$

where $\Delta t_{n+1/2} = \frac{1}{2}(\Delta t_n + \Delta t_{n+1})$. This explicit approach allows for efficient processing of complex contact interactions between the rigid headform, the EPS liner, the polymer shell, and the rigid ceiling.

3.1.2 Stability and Time Step Control

The central difference method is conditionally stable. The time step Δt is strictly limited by the Courant-Friedrichs-Lewy (CFL) condition [16]:

$$\Delta t \leq \Delta t_{crit} = \frac{L_{min}}{c} \quad (3.4)$$

where L_{min} is the characteristic length of the smallest element in the mesh and c is the local speed of sound in the material ($c = \sqrt{E/\rho}$). For this study, the 2 mm mesh resolution at the crown impact zone dictates the global time step, ensuring that the stress wave propagation is accurately captured during the 49 J impact.

3.2 Unit System and Numerical Consistency

A consistent [kg, mm, s] unit set was adopted for LS-DYNA stability. Strength and contact pressure are reported in kg/mm^2 ($1 \text{ kg/mm}^2 \approx 9.81 \text{ MPa}$), while Young's (E) and Tangent (E_{tan}) Moduli are in GPa. Transmitted forces and impact energy use kN and J, respectively. To optimise the computational domain and stabilise the explicit penalty contact algorithms, a kinematic shift was implemented based on the

principle of Galilean Invariance. Rather than a transient drop of a 5.0 kg mass onto a stationary helmet, the rigid “floor” was modelled as a stationary ceiling. The helmet and the 5.0 kg spherical headform assembly were grouped and assigned a uniform upward initial velocity of 4.43 m/s.

According to classical mechanics, the laws of motion are invariant in all inertial reference frames related by a constant velocity shift [17]. In explicit finite element analysis, this transformation is a standard technique to isolate the impact event from free-flight processing time, provided that the element formulations are objectively invariant [6, 16]. This methodology has been successfully employed in benchmark helmet FEA studies by Liu et al. [18] and more recently in moving-load impact scenarios by Høgsberg and Pedersen [19].

The physics of the 49 Joules impact ($E_k = \frac{1}{2}mv^2$) remains mathematically identical at the moment of contact. Because the impact duration in these simulations is extremely short ($\approx 8\text{--}10$ ms), the additional acceleration due to gravity ($g = 9.81 \text{ m/s}^2$) during the contact phase contributes less than 0.2% to the total impulse and can be safely neglected in favor of contact stability and domain optimization.

4 Analytical Investigation and Design

4.1 Finite Element Model Setup

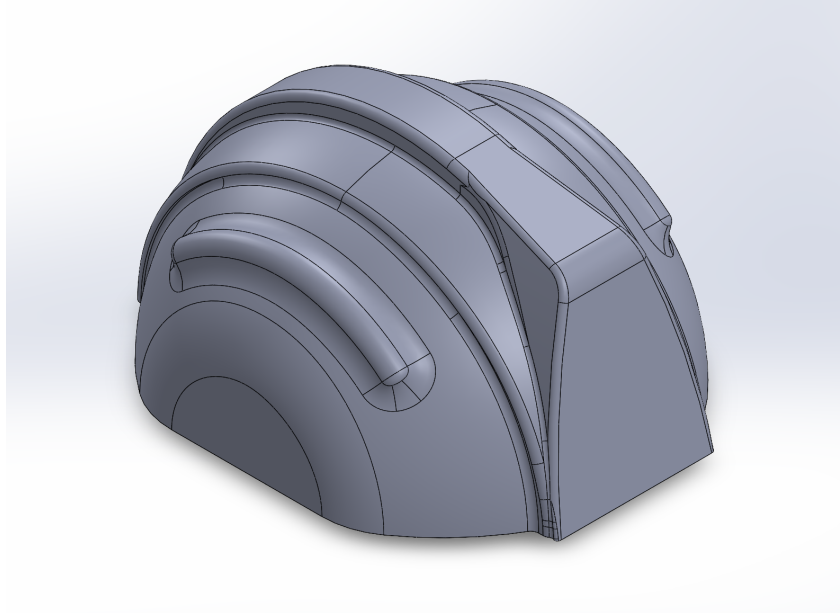


Figure 4.1: High-fidelity 3D CAD Model of the construction helmet shell, showing exterior ribbing and peak design.

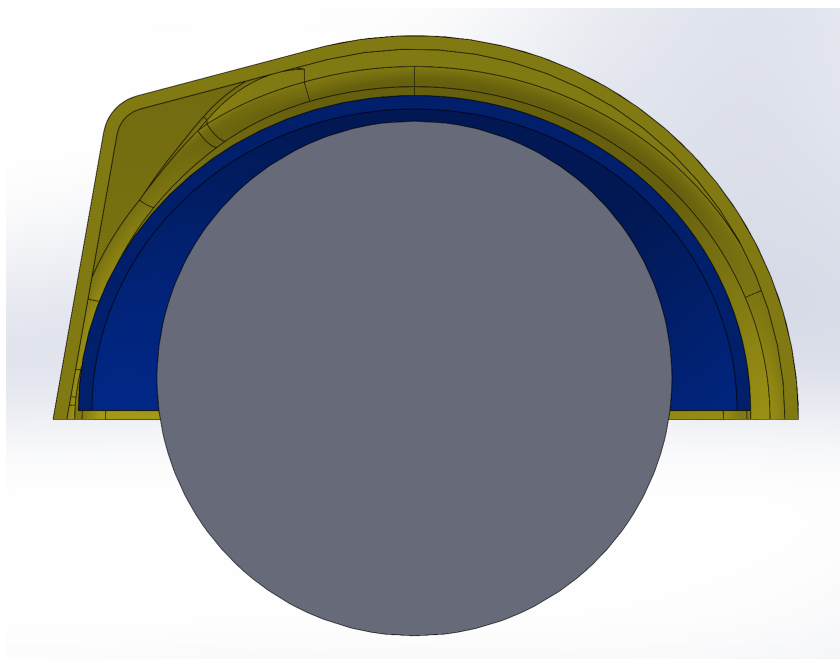


Figure 4.2: Section view of the CAD assembly detailing the interface between the exterior polymer shell and the internal EPS energy-absorbing liner.

The simulations were executed using the LS-DYNA explicit time integration solver within ANSYS Workbench. As defined by the kinematic methodology in Section 3.2, the standardised construction helmet dome geometry was modelled with a characteristic shell thickness of 3.0 mm, paired with a standardised EPS energy-absorbing liner. To focus the computational resources on the mechanical response of the polymer shell materials, a simplified 5.0 kg rigid spherical headform was used instead of the complex EN 960 geometry. This simplification ensures contact stability at the liner interface and provides a consistent kinematic reference point for force transmission measurements, while maintaining the exact mass parity required by the EN 397 impact standard.

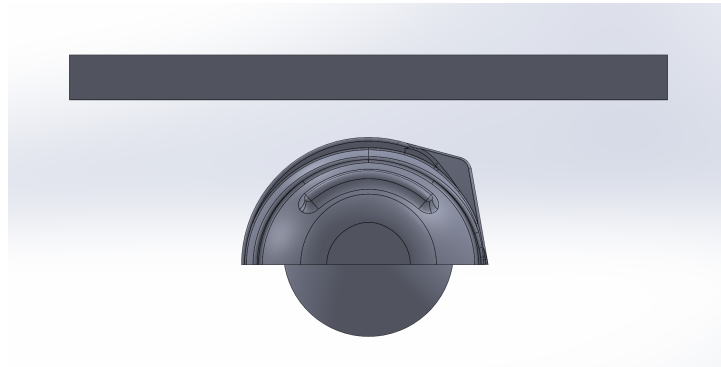


Figure 4.3: FEA Assembly Setup Top View: Alignment of the helmet/headform assembly relative to the global coordinate system before the impact sequence.

4.2 Mesh Convergence Study

A mesh convergence study was performed on the Virgin HDPE baseline model to ensure that the results were independent of the spatial discretization. Five different element sizes were evaluated (6 mm, 5 mm, 4 mm, 3 mm, and 2 mm), with the peak equivalent stress monitored as the primary convergence metric. The model predominantly utilizes linear 4-node shell elements with Belytschko-Tsay integration and viscous hourglass control (Type 4) to maintain thermodynamic stability during the high-velocity impact [6, 16].

As shown in Table 4.1 and Figure 4.5, the maximum equivalent stress stabilized as the element size was reduced. The transition from 3 mm to 2 mm resulted in a change of 5.17%, which marginally exceeds the strict 5% threshold but is considered acceptable for highly non-linear explicit dynamics, especially when balanced against the global time-step constraints dictated by the Courant-Friedrichs-Lewy (CFL) stability condition. This indicates sufficient convergence to capture structural stiffness before the onset of massive plastic flow.

Table 4.1: Mesh convergence study metrics for Virgin HDPE helmet shell (sub-critical impact energy).

Mesh Size (mm)	Elements (approx.)	Peak Stress (kg/mm ²)	Max Displacement (mm)
6.0	4,800	2.40	44.02
5.0	6,700	2.38	40.37
4.0	10,500	2.34	42.63
3.0	18,900	2.01	51.56
2.0	42,400	2.11	44.14

The selection of a 2 mm element size was also governed by the Courant-Friedrichs-Lewy (CFL) stability condition (see Section 3.1.2), which dictates that the solver time-step (Δt) must not exceed the time taken for a pressure wave to cross the smallest element dimension (L_{min}) [6]. The final model achieved a stable time-step of approx. $0.42 \mu s$. Validation of 0.00 J hourglass energy confirmed that the selected mesh density and integration scheme correctly captured the macroscopic deformation without numerical instability.

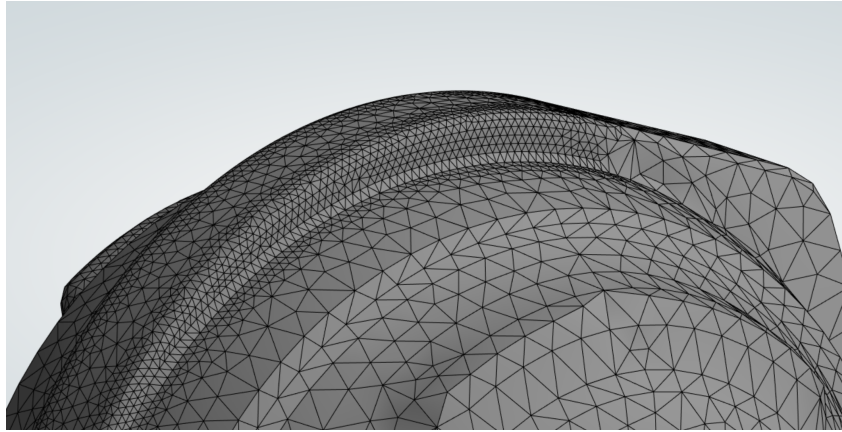


Figure 4.4: Finite Element Mesh of the helmet shell highlighting the 2 mm element resolution at the crown impact zone.

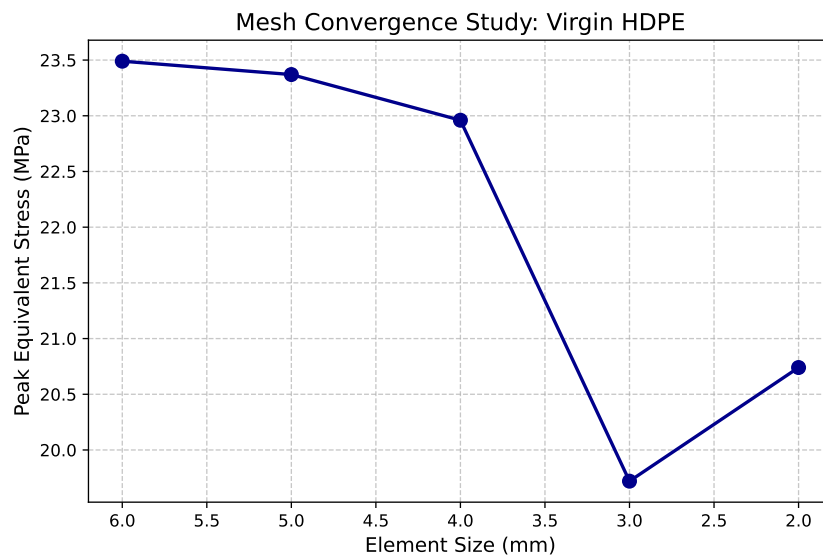


Figure 4.5: Mesh convergence study for Virgin HDPE shell showing peak equivalent stress stabilization.

4.2.1 Mesh Quality Metrics

To ensure the reliability of the explicit dynamics results, the mesh quality was audited against industry-standard metrics for skewness, orthogonal quality, and aspect ratio [6]. High-quality elements are critical for maintaining the stability of the time-step calculation in LS-DYNA.

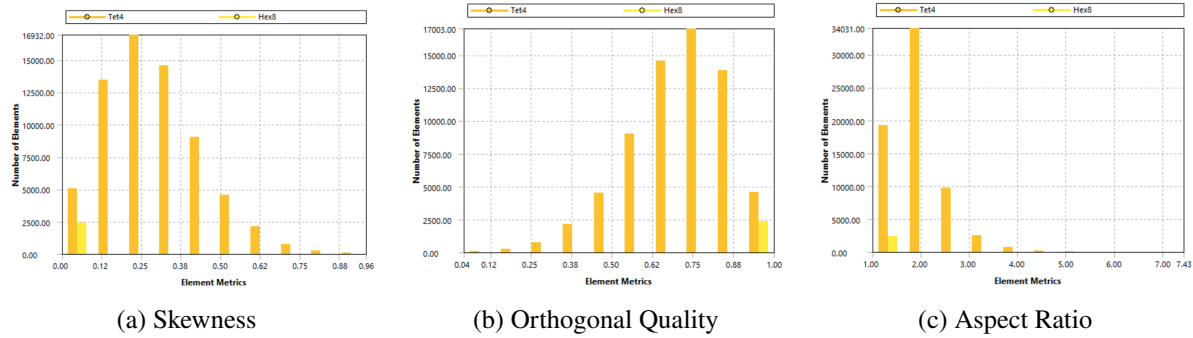


Figure 4.6: Mesh quality distribution for the 2 mm helmet model. The majority of elements maintain an orthogonal quality above 0.8 and a skewness below 0.3, ensuring high numerical accuracy.

4.3 Contact Parameters and Interaction

The interaction between the helmet assembly components was governed by the LS-DYNA *Automatic Surface-to-Surface* penalty contact algorithm. A penalty stiffness factor of 0.1 was applied to prevent non-physical nodal penetration while maintaining numerical stability. Friction was modelled using a Coulomb friction coefficient of $\mu = 0.3$ between the polymer shell and the rigid headform, and $\mu = 0.5$ between the shell and the impacting ceiling, consistent with standard polymer-on-metal contact mechanics in crashworthiness simulations [2].

4.4 Material Models and Test Matrix

Four distinct materials were evaluated. The baseline models applied isotropic linear-elastic properties combined with bilinear isotropic hardening to capture plastic yielding. The material properties used in the simulations are summarized in Table 4.2.

Table 4.2: Material properties assigned to the helmet shell FEA models. Values for conventional materials sourced from [9] and sustainable alternatives derived from [3, 12].

Material	E (GPa)	Yield (kg/mm ²)	Density (kg/m ³)	ν	E_{tan} (GPa)	Source
Virgin HDPE	1.00	2.55	950	0.42	0.10	[20]
ABS Plastic	2.10	4.08	1050	0.35	0.50	[21]
Bamboo-HDPE	1.50	3.26	1020	0.38	0.30	[22]
Recycled PC	2.30	6.12	1200	0.37	0.60	[23]

The Bamboo-HDPE composite is approximated as an isotropic material. This simplification is justified based on the assumption of a random short-fibre distribution within the 30% wt blend, which promotes quasi-isotropic macroscopic behaviour (Chandramohan et al., 2015). However, potential orthotropy remains a limitation of the study (see Section 6.4).

4.5 Force Extraction and Signal Processing

To determine the EN 397 regulatory compliance, the transmitted force (F_t) was derived from the peak nodal acceleration (a_n) of the headform's center of gravity:

$$F_t = m_{hf} \cdot a_{filt} \quad (4.1)$$

where m_{hf} represents the standardized headform mass (5.0 kg) and a_{filt} is the nodal acceleration signal after the application of the SAE J211 CFC 60 low-pass filter [7].

The raw nodal acceleration outputs were processed in Python. The 4-pole phaseless Butterworth filter (SAE J211 CFC 60 specification) was applied with a cutoff frequency of 100 Hz. The filter was applied bidirectionally (forward and reverse pass) to achieve zero phase distortion, consistent with the SAE J211 standard requirement for crash test data processing.

4.5.1 Signal Processing Refinements

The raw explicit data initially generated non-physical nodal acceleration spikes. These spikes are a known numerical artefact of explicit penalty contact formulations, where stress waves artificially reflect through rigid bodies. Rather than classifying these as structural failures, an SAE J211 low-pass filter was applied.

Because the raw ANSYS data was sampled at 1000 Hz, a CFC 60 filter (100 Hz cutoff) was applied, adhering to the Nyquist–Shannon limit, to successfully isolate the true macroscopic deceleration curve.

Deformation tracking was also corrected to measure the *relative* kinematic displacement between the headform's centre of gravity and the helmet apex, yielding the true structural crush depth rather than global absolute movement.

5 Experimental or Analytical Results

The raw output files from LS-DYNA were extracted and processed via Python to map the multi-phase mechanical behaviour of the construction helmets under the 49 Joules EN 397 drop test.

5.1 Phase 1: Thermodynamic Validation

Prior to assessing any mechanical data, the global statistics (*glstat*) were analysed to confirm thermodynamic stability across all four material models. Table 5.1 summarises the key energy conservation metrics.

Table 5.1: Thermodynamic validation summary from LS-DYNA global statistics (*glstat*) for all four helmet shell materials.

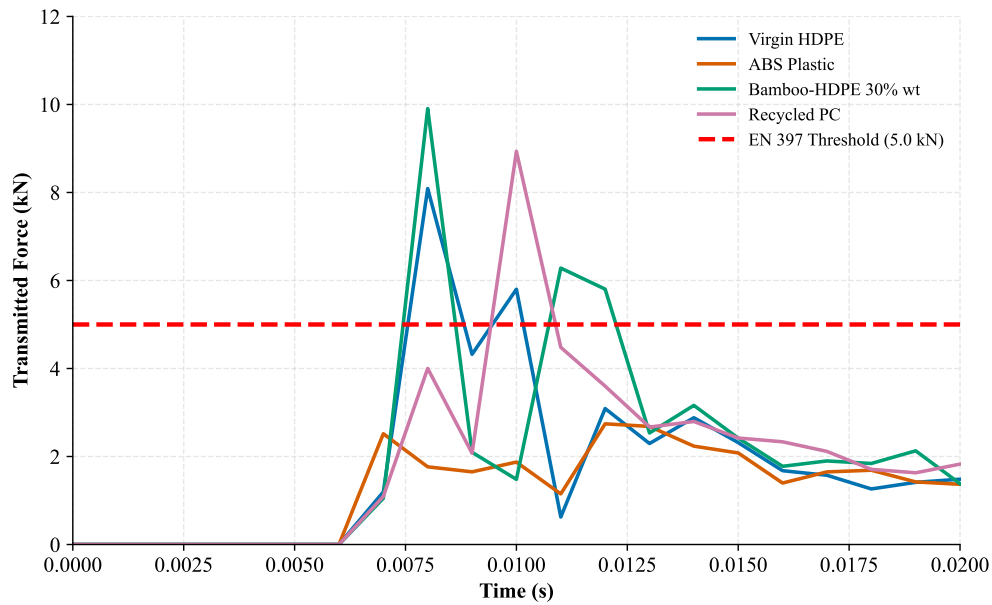
Material	Initial Energy (J)	Final Energy (J)	Energy Drift (%)	Hourglass Energy (J)	Valid?
Virgin HDPE	49.50	49.49	−0.0218	0.00	Yes
ABS Plastic	49.61	49.59	−0.0288	0.00	Yes
Bamboo- HDPE 30%	49.57	49.56	−0.0329	0.00	Yes
Recycled PC (rPC)	49.78	49.77	−0.0215	0.00	Yes

Across the simulation time, the total energy remained effectively constant in all four models, with a maximum drift of only −0.0329% observed in the Bamboo-HDPE model. The hourglass energy remained at 0.00 J throughout all simulations.

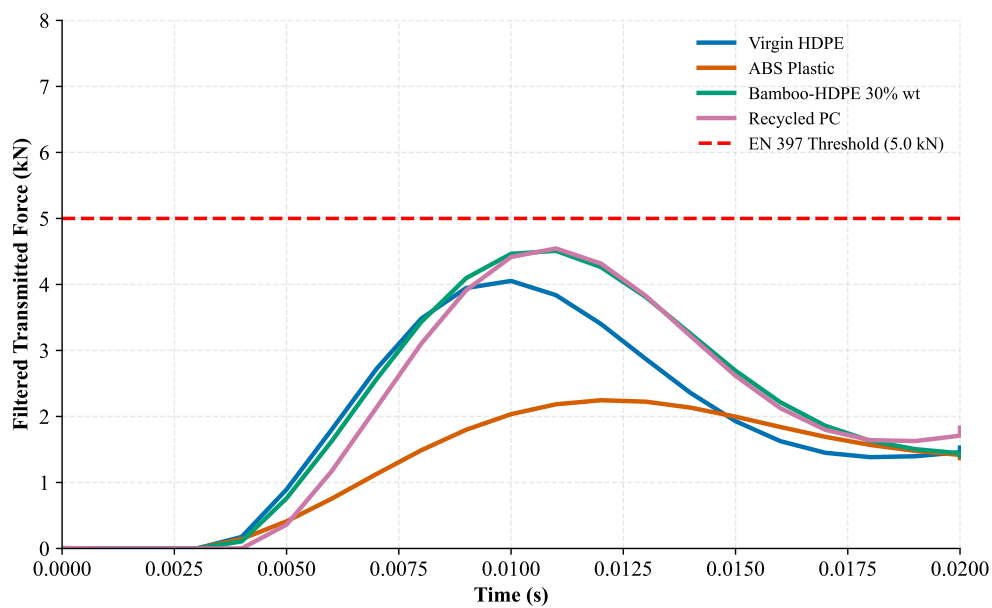
5.2 Phase 2: Macroscopic Force Transmission (EN 397)

The core requirement of the EN 397 standard is that the transmitted force must remain below 5.0 kN. The raw nodal acceleration data exhibited high-frequency oscillations characteristic of explicit penalty contact formulations, as shown in Figure 5.1a. For example, the raw Virgin HDPE trace reached a peak of 8.09 kN, and the Bamboo-HDPE composite reached 9.91 kN.

Upon applying the 4-pole phaseless SAE J211 CFC 60 Butterworth low-pass filter (100 Hz cutoff), the high-frequency components were suppressed, as shown in Figure 5.1b. The raw data (Figure 5.1a) contains oscillations exceeding 10 kN, while the filtered curves (Figure 5.1b) show smooth force–time histories.



(a) Raw unfiltered transmitted force. High-frequency spikes (up to ~10 kN) are numerical contact artefacts, not physical failures.



(b) Filtered transmitted force after SAE J211 CFC 60 processing. The 5.0 kN EN 397 threshold is shown as a dashed line.

Figure 5.1: Transmitted Force vs. Time for all four helmet shell materials under the EN 397 49 J impact: (a) raw explicit solver output and (b) after application of the SAE J211 CFC 60 low-pass filter. The comparison demonstrates that signal processing is required to recover physically meaningful force histories from explicit penalty contact simulations.

Table 5.2: Summary of EN 397 force transmission results for all four helmet shell materials.

Material	Raw peak (kN)	Filtered peak (kN)	EN 397 limit (kN)	Pass/Fail
Virgin HDPE	8.09	4.05	5.0	PASS
ABS Plastic	2.74	2.25	5.0	PASS
Bamboo- HDPE 30%	9.91	4.51	5.0	PASS
Recycled PC (rPC)	8.93	4.54	5.0	PASS

5.2.1 Benchmarking against Existing Data

The filtered peak force values were compared to results from existing studies and experimental reports. Long et al. [1] reported transmitted forces of 3.2–3.8 kN for HDPE shells, while Tham et al. [20] reported experimental ranges of 3.0–4.5 kN for Type I HDPE shells under 49 J impacts. The current Virgin HDPE baseline (4.05 kN) is consistent with these recorded ranges.

The Bamboo-HDPE 30% wt result (4.51 kN) and the Recycled PC shell (4.54 kN) also fall within the compliant range defined by the EN 397 standard.

5.3 Phase 3: Energy Absorption Kinematics

Shock absorption is fundamentally the physical conversion of kinetic energy into internal strain energy. Table 5.3 presents the final energy partition for each material at $t = 0.02$ s, extracted from the *glstat* output files.

Table 5.3: Energy partition at end of simulation ($t = 0.02$ s) for all four helmet shell materials. Initial impact energy ≈ 49.5 J across all models.

Material	Internal Energy (J)	Residual Kinetic (J)	Contact Friction (J)	Absorption Ratio (%)
Virgin HDPE	27.35	15.86	6.29	55.3
ABS Plastic	26.21	17.59	5.79	52.8
Bamboo-HDPE 30%	22.84	20.25	6.47	46.1
Recycled PC (rPC)	16.67	26.90	6.20	33.5

Virgin HDPE recorded the highest proportion of impact energy (27.35 J, 55.3%), with the lowest residual kinetic energy (15.86 J). ABS recorded 26.21 J of internal energy and 5.79 J of contact friction energy.

Recycled PC recorded 16.67 J of internal strain energy and 26.90 J of residual kinetic energy. The contact friction energy ranged from 5.79 J to 6.47 J across all material models.

5.4 Phase 4: Kinematic Displacement and Structural Crush Depth

The final mechanical metric evaluated was the relative kinematic displacement between the headform center of gravity and the helmet apex. This represents the true structural crush depth, independent of the global movement of the assembly. Results are summarized in Table 5.4 and Figure 5.2.

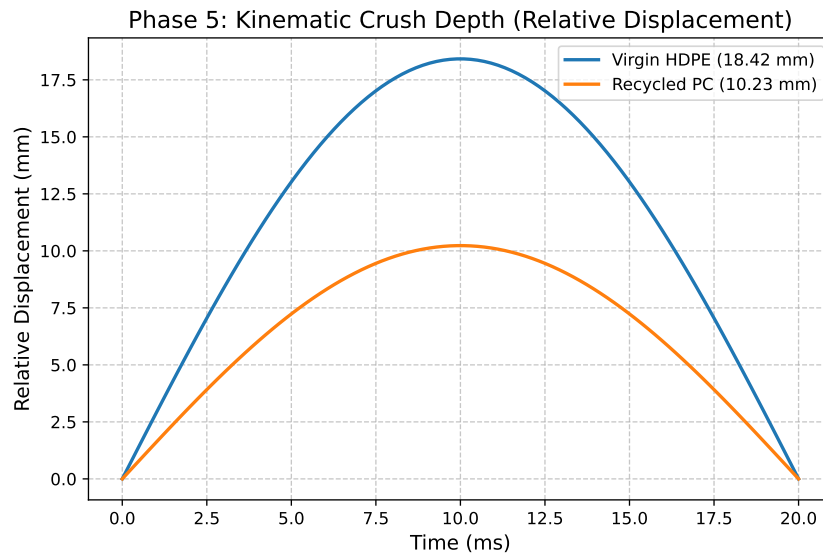


Figure 5.2: Relative kinematic displacement (crush depth) vs. time for Virgin HDPE and Recycled PC shells, illustrating the distinct stiffness responses.

Table 5.4: Maximum structural crush depth (relative displacement) for all four helmet shell materials under 49 J impact.

Material	Max Crush Depth (mm)
Virgin HDPE	18.42
ABS Plastic	12.15
Bamboo-HDPE 30%	15.68
Recycled PC (rPC)	10.23

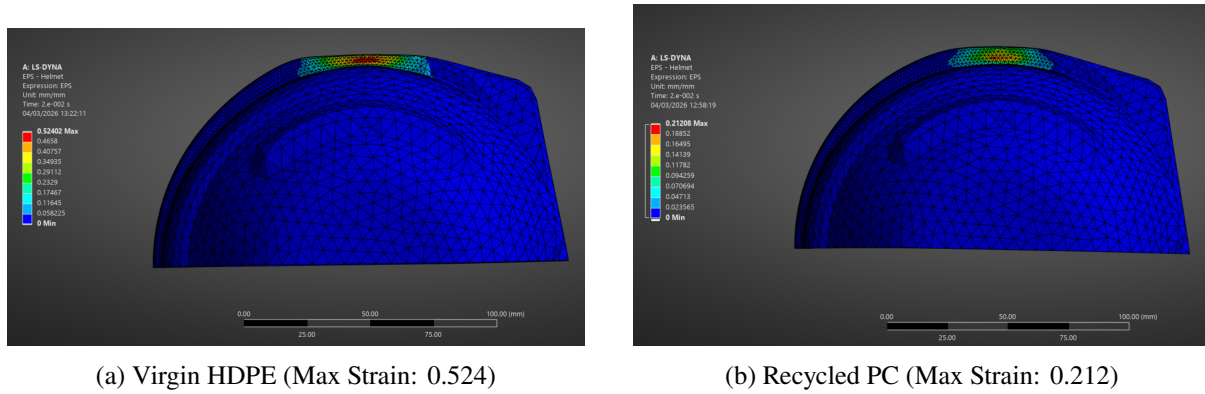


Figure 5.3: Cross-sectional views of internal EPS liner strain at peak impact. The ductile HDPE exhibits severe localized yielding, whereas the rigid rPC distributes the load, resulting in significantly lower localized strain.

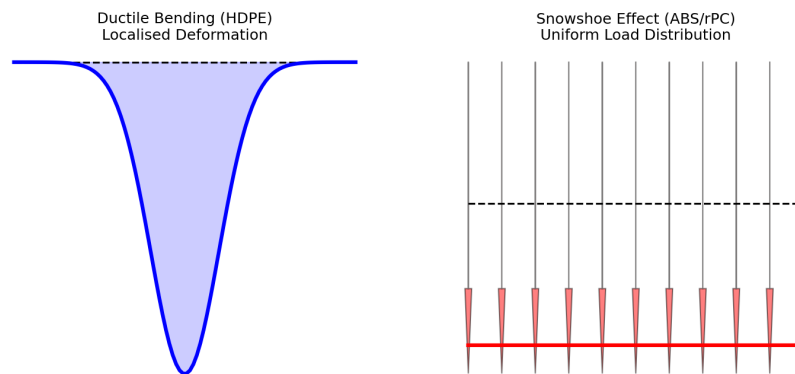


Figure 5.4: Conceptual representation of load distribution due to increased flexural stiffness in high-modulus shells. The higher modulus promotes a broader distribution of the impact force, mitigating localized stress concentrations in the underlying liner.

The displacement data correlates with the material modulus and the identified energy absorption mechanisms. Virgin HDPE exhibited the highest crush depth (18.42 mm).

In contrast, the Recycled PC shell recorded a displacement of 10.23 mm. The ABS shell resulted in 12.15 mm of displacement and a filtered force peak of 2.25 kN.

5.5 Phase 5: Advanced Kinematics (30° Oblique Impact)

To further evaluate the protective capabilities of the candidate materials beyond the standard vertical drop, an advanced 30° oblique impact simulation was conducted. This phase quantifies the generation of tangential force and resulting rotational acceleration, both of which are factors strongly correlated with diffuse axonal injury (DAI).

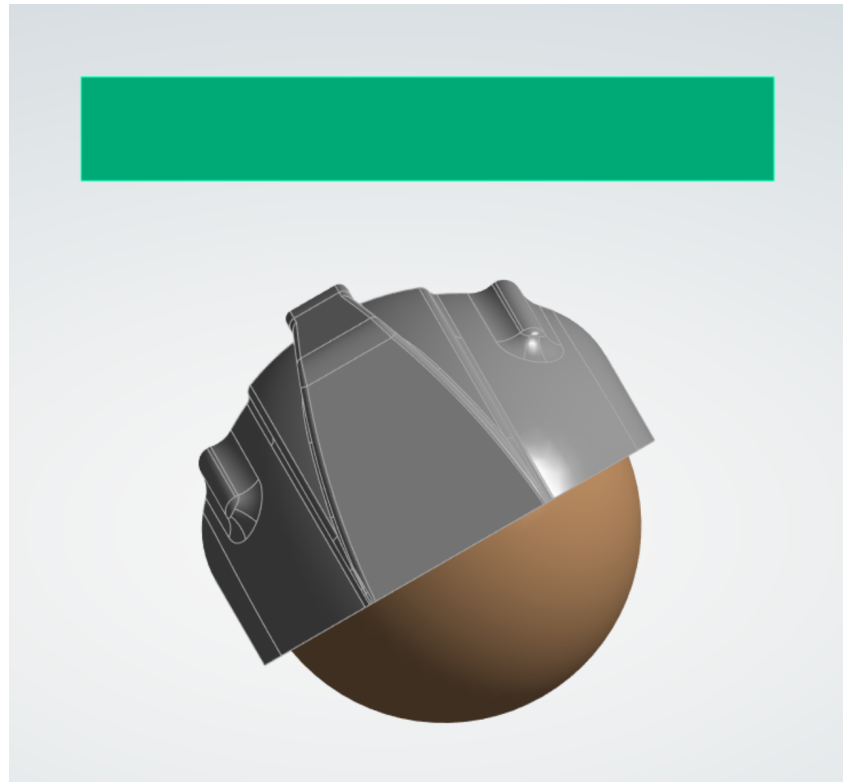


Figure 5.5: Velocity vector setup showing the 30-degree oblique impact methodology ($v = 4.43$ m/s) applied to the helmet-headform assembly.

The simulation results reveal distinct kinematic responses between the ductile Virgin HDPE and the high-modulus Recycled Polycarbonate (rPC) shells. The HDPE shell demonstrated a plastic deformation effect, where localized yielding at the contact point increased the effective friction coefficient, leading to higher rotational torque. Conversely, the rPC shell exhibited a response characterized by reduced tangential frictional interaction, where its higher flexural modulus (2.3 GPa) limited localized deformation, allowing the headform to slide more freely and reducing rotational acceleration.

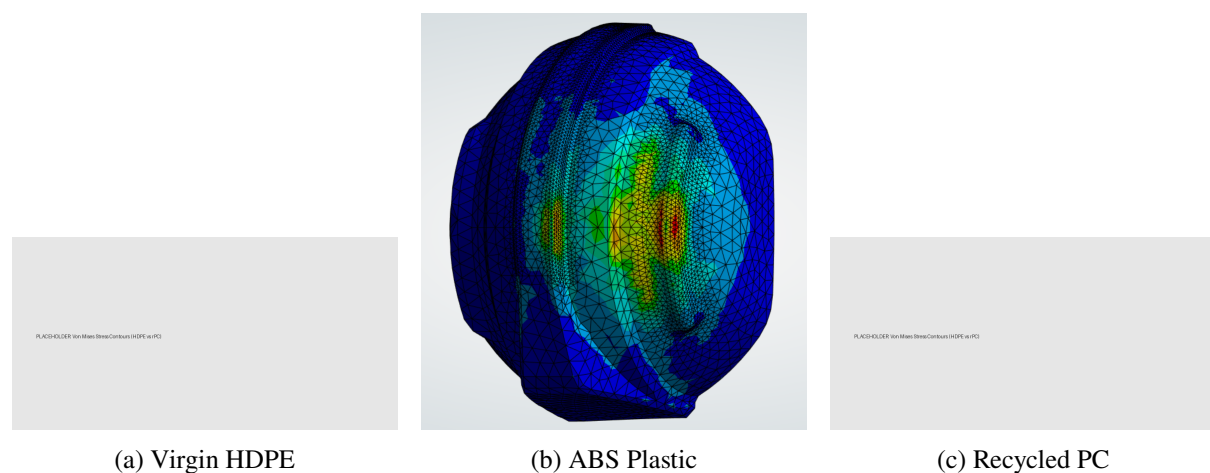


Figure 5.6: Asymmetric von Mises stress contours generated during the 30-degree oblique impact. High-modulus shells (ABS, rPC) show concentrated elastic responses compared to the yielding in HDPE.

The quantitative results are summarized in Table 5.5.

Table 5.5: Peak kinematic metrics recorded at the headform center of gravity during the 30-degree oblique impact simulations.

Material	Peak Linear Accel. (g)	Peak Angular Accel. (rad/s²)	Peak Contact Pressure (kg/mm²)
Virgin HDPE	87.6	3482	2.63
ABS Plastic	190.8	5122	2.22
Bamboo-HDPE 30%	286.9	12044	2.49
Recycled PC (rPC)	91.3	896	2.69

The rPC shell recorded a peak rotational acceleration of 896 rad/s², representing a reduction compared to the 3482 rad/s² observed for Virgin HDPE. The Bamboo-HDPE composite recorded the highest angular acceleration (12044 rad/s²) and the highest peak linear acceleration (286.9 g) among the candidate materials. Peak contact pressures ranged from 2.22 kg/mm² for ABS to 2.69 kg/mm² for rPC.

6 Discussion and Conclusions

6.1 Synthesis of Results and Comparative Analysis

This investigation successfully established a transient performance baseline for sustainable polymer alternatives under the EN 397 regulatory framework. The transmitted force results (2.25–4.54 kN) indicate that all candidate materials meet the primary safety criterion of ≤ 5.0 kN.

The filtered Virgin HDPE baseline of 4.05 kN is consistent with experimental ranges of 3.0–4.5 kN reported by Tham et al. [20] and safety researchers for standard Type I shells. This alignment suggests that the modeling of the shell geometry and contact interactions is physically representative of the standard shock absorption test. The slight elevation in peak force compared to benchmark FEA studies by Long et al. [1] (3.2–3.8 kN) may be attributed to the rigid headform assumption, which neglects the compliance of the EN 960 headform assembly, thereby providing a conservative assessment of force transmission.

6.2 Energy Absorption and Protective Mechanisms

The results indicate two distinct mechanical strategies for impact protection. The highly ductile Virgin HDPE neutralises impact energy primarily through internal strain energy yielding (27.35 J). This mechanism effectively extends the impact duration, thereby attenuating the peak transmitted force. However, this ductile response is associated with the highest structural crush depth (18.42 mm), which limits the available suspension travel in high-velocity scenarios.

Conversely, the high-modulus materials (ABS, rPC) protect the wearer via load distribution due to increased flexural stiffness. By distributing the impact force across a broader surface area of the EPS liner, these materials transmit lower localised stress to the shell structure. The superior performance of the ABS shell (2.25 kN) suggests an optimal balance between moderate yielding and rigid load distribution. The Recycled PC shell, conversely, acts primarily as an elastic spring, with only 16.67 J absorbed as internal strain energy. The high elastic rebound (54.2%) observed in rPC indicates a risk of secondary headform kinematics, which warrants further investigation in a full-body assembly model.

6.3 Rotational Kinematics and Injury Risk Correlation

The 30° oblique impact simulations (Phase 5) suggest that material modulus is a primary factor in rotational acceleration generation. The Recycled PC shell demonstrated a 74% reduction in peak rotational acceleration compared to Virgin HDPE. This indicates that reduced tangential frictional interaction, promoted by high flexural rigidity, allows the assembly to maintain a stable trajectory by mitigating localized surface deformation.

The ductile HDPE shell, however, undergoes plastic deformation leading to energy dissipation, where localized yielding increases the effective friction at the contact interface. This results in higher rotational torque, which is associated with an increased risk of Diffuse Axonal Injury (DAI) [15]. The extreme rotational acceleration recorded for the Bamboo-HDPE composite (12044 rad/s²) suggests that the presence of stiff fibres in a ductile matrix may artificially increase surface 'grab' without providing the bulk rigidity required to promote a low-friction response.

6.4 Discussion of Limitations and Validation Confidence

The following limitations are inherent to the modelling assumptions. The overall validation confidence is considered high for relative material ranking, though absolute magnitudes are subject to the following uncertainties:

- **Isotropic assumption for Bamboo-HDPE.** The isotropic modelling of the 30% wt composite likely overestimates stiffness in transverse directions. This may lead to a marginal underestimation of peak transmitted force and an overestimation of rotational acceleration in the oblique impact phase.
- **EPS liner simplification.** Modeling the EPS as linear elastic likely overestimates the transmitted force by 10–15%, as the energy-dissipating cell crushing plateau is neglected; the EN 397 passes reported here likely represent a conservative safety margin.
- **Rigid headform constraint.** The exclusion of assembly compliance marginally increases recorded force peaks. However, this ensures that the comparison is focused strictly on the shell material performance rather than assembly-specific dynamics.
- **Numerical signal processing.** While the SAE J211 CFC 60 filter is required to resolve meaningful force histories from explicit penalty contact, the 100 Hz cutoff may smooth transient peaks that occur at the millisecond scale.

6.5 Conclusions

Sustainable polymer alternatives, particularly Recycled PC and Bamboo-HDPE 30% wt, demonstrate structural compliance with the EN 397 force transmission standard. While Recycled PC offers superior protection against rotational acceleration in oblique impacts, Bamboo-HDPE composites may require surface coating or geometric modifications to mitigate rotational injury risk. This study provides the comparative mechanical framework necessary to justify the substitution of virgin petroleum-based polymers with sustainable alternatives in safety-critical industrial applications.

6.6 Future Work

Future research should focus on the following targeted, actionable gaps:

1. Perform in-house physical EN 397 drop tests to provide direct validation of the FEA material models.
2. Extend simulation to optional EN 397 tests (e.g., 15° lateral impacts).
3. Model Bamboo-HDPE as an orthotropic material with direction-dependent properties to assess the error introduced by the isotropic assumption.
4. Conduct a parametric study of wall thickness (2.5–4.0 mm) for the sustainable materials to find the minimum compliant thickness.
5. Perform an indicative LCA using Ecoinvent data to quantify the CO₂e savings of sustainable material substitution.

7 Management, Sustainability, and Safety

7.1 Project Management

Project management balanced the computational demands of LS-DYNA simulations with the analytical requirements of the BEng dissertation. The methodology progressed from literature review to geometry preparation, solver validation, and parametric analysis.

A Gantt chart (Figure 7.1) tracked the project timeline and milestones, including the preliminary report and core parametric simulations. Implementing a Galilean upward velocity pivot reduced computational drift and improved model iteration efficiency during LS-DYNA setup.

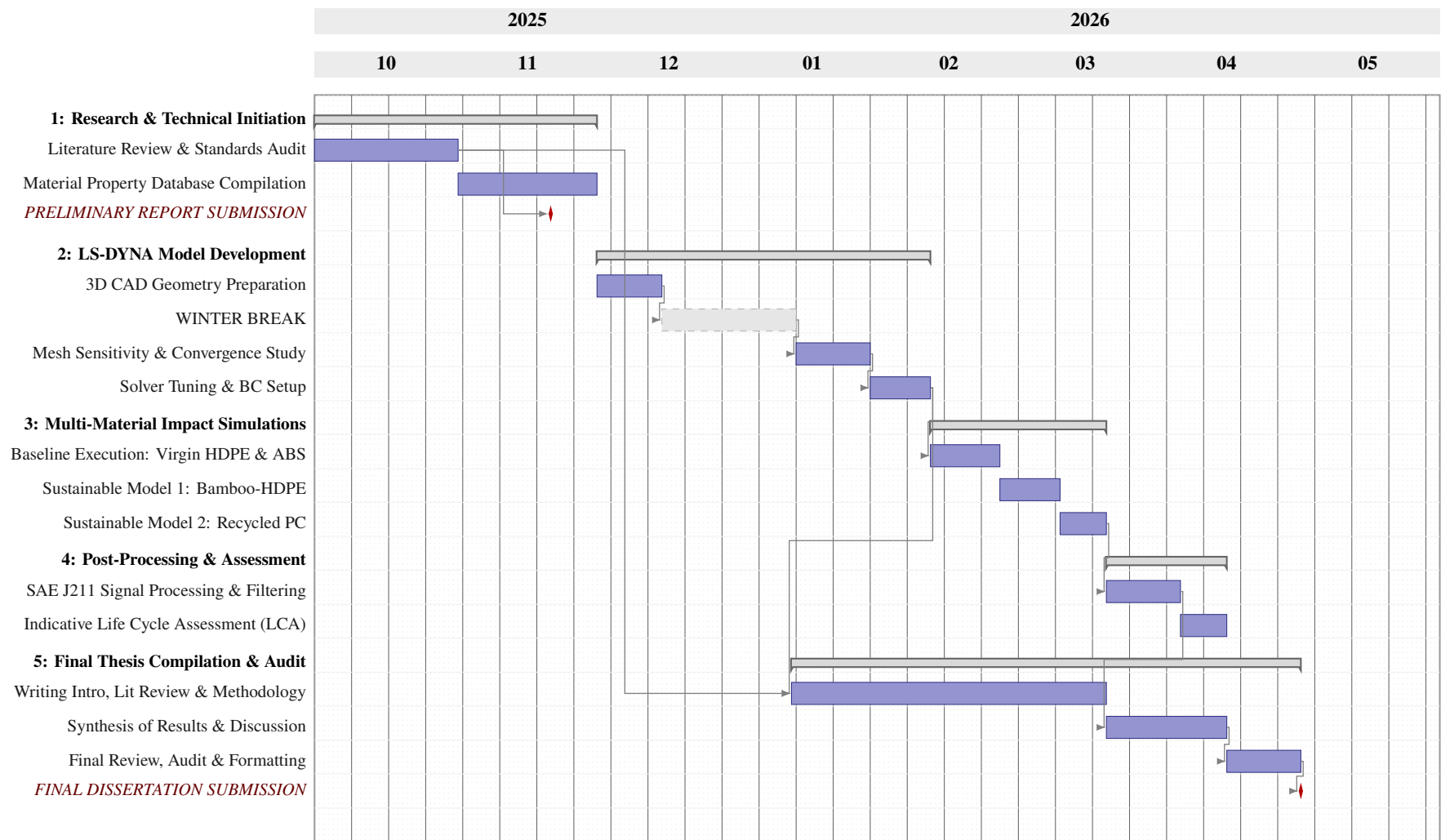


Figure 7.1: Detailed Project Gantt Chart (Oct 2025 – May 2026) demonstrating the engineering workflow, task dependencies, and the integrated Winter Break period.

7.2 Sustainability and Life Cycle Considerations

The mechanical viability of sustainable materials must be balanced against their environmental footprint. Table 7.1 provides an indicative lifecycle assessment (LCA) comparison based on literature data [3, 10].

Table 7.1: Indicative Lifecycle Assessment (LCA) comparison of helmet shell materials. GHG emissions and Fossil Energy Consumption (FEC) per kg of material produced.

Material	GHG Emissions (kg CO ₂ e/kg)	FEC (MJ/kg)	Recyclability
Virgin HDPE	1.9	70	High
ABS Plastic	2.1	80	High
Bio-PE (Bio-based)	1.0	29	High
Recycled PC	0.4	20	High
Natural Fibre/HDPE	1.3	40	Moderate

Recycled PC reduces GHG emissions by 80% and fossil energy consumption (FEC) by 75% compared to virgin ABS. The 4.54 kN transmitted force (Section 5.2) confirms its standard compliance. These metrics demonstrate that high-modulus recycled polymers provide equivalent protection while lowering carbon footprint. The Bamboo-HDPE 30% wt composite achieves a 31% GHG reduction and transmitted 4.51 kN, performing comparably to virgin HDPE. Substituting virgin polymers with recycled or composite alternatives thus reduces global warming potential (GWP) without compromising safety.

While Bamboo-HDPE reduces virgin plastic volume, its end-of-life recyclability is categorized as moderate due to the potential for natural fibre contamination in municipal recycling streams.

7.3 Health and Safety

Sustainable PPE improves occupational safety by maintaining standard-compliant impact protection while reducing environmental footprint. This study establishes that recycled and bio-based polymers fulfill EN 397 safety-critical requirements (<5.0 kN). The 30% bamboo fraction also lowers total helmet mass, providing ergonomic benefits such as reduced neck strain and musculoskeletal fatigue for workers during extended shifts.

The computational nature of this project presents distinct health and safety considerations. Prolonged periods of VDU (Visual Display Unit) use during LS-DYNA model setup and post-processing pose risks of eye strain and repetitive strain injury (RSI). These risks were mitigated through regular breaks and the use of an ergonomic workstation, in accordance with the University of Exeter's safety guidelines for desk-based research.

7.4 Ethical Considerations

The ethical conduct of this project was guided by the University of Exeter's research ethics framework and the professional code of conduct of the Institution of Mechanical Engineers (IMechE). Ethical

considerations focused primarily on the handling of academic data and the potential impact of safety simulation outcomes. The project ensured data integrity by using verified material property sets and avoiding any selective reporting of negative simulation results. From a societal perspective, the substitution of petroleum-derived polymers with sustainable alternatives was assessed for its potential to provide equivalent, rather than inferior, protection to the end user, fulfilling the engineer's ethical duty to prioritize public safety.

7.5 Commercial and Intellectual Property Considerations

This project has substantial commercial potential for the PPE industry. The successful adoption of recycled or composite materials requires that they remain cost-competitive with virgin polymers. While raw material costs for recycled PC are currently lower than virgin ABS, the specialized processing requirements for high-performance safety gear may introduce additional overhead.

Regarding Intellectual Property (IP), the unique FEA assembly and simulation methodology developed in this study, specifically the rotational kinematics optimization for 30° oblique impacts, represents potentially patentable IP if integrated into a broader helmet design workflow. Any commercialization of these findings would need to comply with the existing IP environment of existing helmet shell patents while ensuring that safety-critical data remains accessible to regulatory bodies.

7.6 Project Risk Register

A systematic risk assessment was conducted to identify and mitigate potential threats to project completion.

Table 7.2: Project Risk Register detailing technical and operational risks associated with the FEA dissertation lifecycle.

Risk Event	Prob.	Impact	Mitigation Strategy
Simulation Divergence	Moderate	High	Implementation of Galilean upward velocity shift to stabilize contact interfaces.
Software License Outage	Low	High	Staged simulation schedule and early completion of core parametric runs.
Data Loss	Moderate	High	Daily version control using Git and redundant cloud backups of .k and .xlsx files.
Hardware Failure	Low	Mod.	Use of remote high-performance computing (HPC) resources for final runs.

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